

DEAD GAME

An exploitative whodunnit takes off from the Jessica Lal murder but crashlands into dullsville



SIX SUSPECTS
by VIKAS SWARUP
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■ By Brinda Bose

Let's call it a Delhi-whodunnit. Inveterate (if closet) Page 3 trackers that most of us are, we must admit that when the P3P appear on headline news—stalking, raping, murdering—we are perpetually riveted. The more powerful, the more beautiful, rich and corrupt they are, the juicier the tale, the more sting in its rear, the more sustained its life in the notoriously fickle public memory, the more value extracted by the media for the longer time...

So why, then, does *Six Suspects*, a second novel from senior Indian diplomat Vikas Swarup, leave one with an unhappy aftertaste, a feeling that the abhorrent case of the murder of Jessica

Lal in April 1999 is not at all well-served by this thinly-veiled but over-imagined take on its intrigues and intricacies? We have, of course, always evinced the greatest curiosity for the way the political mafia extricates leverage in our midst. And a scoop on Uttar Pradesh, where the prime suspect's father swings his money-laden baton, is sheer bonanza any time. But the Jessica Lal case was the first in which sustained public outrage against a manipulated verdict actually forced a re-trial and a re-sentencing. It also happens to be a case which is ongoing. Could it be that we have a conscience yet, and that we are discomfited by the fictitious fingering of a tale that re-exposes our capital(ist) dystopia?

Swarup's tale begins where Ruby Gill (Jessica Lal)'s case has not ended—with the fatal shooting of the prime accused, Vicky Rai (Manu Sharma) at a glittering Mehrauli farmhouse party hosted by the man himself to celebrate his acquittal for the alleged murder of the young woman

EXCERPT

'No, Sir, and I don't care. The rules are the same for everyone. You will not get another drink.'

Vicky Rai went into a rage. 'You bloody bitch!' He screamed and whipped out a revolver from his suit pocket. 'This will teach you a lesson!' He fired at her twice, shooting her in the face and the neck, in front of at least fifty guests. Ruby Gill dropped dead and Mango descended into bedlam. A friend of Vicky's reportedly grabbed his arm, led him out to his Mercedes and drove him out of the restaurant. Fifteen days later, Vicky Rai was arrested from Lucknow, produced before a magistrate and managed yet again to obtain bail.

A murder over the mere refusal of a drink shook the conscience of the nation. The combination of Vicky Rai's notoriety and Ruby Gill's beauty ensured that the case did not disappear from the headlines for weeks to come.

